

# CHORD FUNCTION & CADENCES

Every chord belongs to one of three functional groups — and those groups follow a universal narrative arc from home to tension and back.

## THE THREE FUNCTIONAL CATEGORIES (KEY OF C MAJOR)

### FUNCTION 1

#### TONIC (HOME)

Primary: **I (Cmaj7)**

**I**   **vi**   **iii**

*I is primary home. vi is the relative minor — shares 2 notes with I, so it sounds like home but with a sadder tint. iii shares stable tones but is rarely used today as a tonic chord.*

### FUNCTION 2

#### SUBDOMINANT (DEPARTURE)

Primary: **IV (Fmaj7)**

**IV**   **ii**   **vii°**

*IV is the classic departure — adds color and motion away from home. ii is the modern, jazzier subdominant (darker flavor). vii° is a contemporary option used in pop and neo-soul progressions.*

### FUNCTION 3

#### DOMINANT (TENSION)

Primary: **V (G7)**

**V**   **vii°**

*V7 contains the tritone — the engine of harmonic tension. Creates the strongest pull back to I. vii° is the classical dominant substitute but sounds dated in modern pop contexts. V7 is the go-to.*

#### HOME

**I** • **vi** • **iii**  
TONIC



adds color  
and motion

#### DEPARTURE

**IV** • **ii** • **vii°**  
SUBDOMINANT



creates  
urgency

#### TENSION

**V** • **vii°**  
DOMINANT



resolves

#### HOME

**I**  
RESOLUTION

## THE 4 CADENCE TYPES

### Authentic Cadence

**V → I (or V7 → I)**

THE PERIOD AT THE END OF A SENTENCE

*The strongest resolution in Western music. PAC (Perfect Authentic Cadence): V7 → I in root position with scale degree 1 on top. IAC (Imperfect): V → I but 3rd or 5th on top — slightly softer landing.*

### Plagal Cadence

**IV → I**

THE "AMEN" CADENCE — PEACEFUL, GENTLE

*The church cadence. Softer and more peaceful than authentic — no tritone tension driving the resolution. Common in gospel, hymns, and folk. Ends on a sigh rather than a full stop.*

### Half Cadence

**any chord → V**

THE QUESTION MARK — CREATES ANTICIPATION

*Ends ON the dominant — pauses on tension instead of resolving it. Like a musical question mark: "something is coming." Often used at phrase midpoints before the answer phrase resolves fully.*

### Deceptive Cadence

**V → vi (or V → ♭VI)**

THE PLOT TWIST — DELAYS RESOLUTION

*V seems ready to resolve to I — but lands on vi instead. vi shares 2 notes with I (C-E share with Am's A-C-E), so it feels like home but with a sadder tint. Delays the full resolution beautifully. V → ♭VI is an even more dramatic deception.*